

Echo and the Mountain of Choices

(Ages 6–9)

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Echo and the Mountain of Choices



Page 2

Deep in the Sunken Valley, where the water was cool and the moss was soft, lived a little axolotl named Echo. She was a Junior Scout, and today was the day of her biggest test.

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Echo gazed up at the Shimmering Peak. Legend has it that at the very top grew a flower that changed colors with your feelings. Echo wanted to see it more than anything.

Page 4

She pulled on her favorite green adventure cloak and flipped up the hood. She grabbed her pearl-lantern and whispered, "Today is the day I find my inner glow."

Page 5

But standing at the bottom, the mountain looked much bigger than it did from her window. It looked like a giant wall of "No" ... or maybe a place full of choices she hadn't made yet.

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Echo's tummy filled with scared knots. Her tail gave a nervous twitch. "Maybe I'm too small for such a big mountain," she whispered.

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Just then, a sparkly trail appeared on a rock. It was Shelly the Snail. "Trouble, little explorer?" Shelly hummed, her voice slow and warm like honey.

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"It's too tall, Shelly! I'm not ready." Shelly blinked her kind eyes. "A mountain is just lots of tiny steps stacked high. The secret is to try, try, try."

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Echo looked at her feet and took one small step. Then another. "One, two, three," she counted. "Hey! I'm actually moving!"

Page 10

The path was beautiful at first. Echo marched past giant purple-spotted mushrooms and waved at a busy blue ladybug. A brave little glow warmed her chest.

Page 11

But then TRIP-FLIP-TUMBLE! Echo's foot caught on a wiggly root, and she tumbled into a patch of soft dirt.

Page 12

"Oof!" Echo sat up and dusted off her cloak. The sacred knots returned. "Maybe I'm not a real explorer after all," she sighed. "I should go home."

Page 13

She looked back down at the valley. It seemed smaller now. Echo blinked. She had already climbed higher than she ever had before.

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"I'm not back at the start," Echo said. "I'll try one more time." Carefully, she stepped over the root and kept going.

Page 15

Higher and higher she climbed. The air smelled fresh, like rain and sun-warmed rocks. Echo felt closer to the sky than ever before.

Page 16

Suddenly, the path changed. Solid dirt turned into loose, sparkly gravel. It looked like a river of marbles.

Page 17

Each step forward slid her two steps back. Slide, step. Slide, step. Her legs felt tired, and her heart felt heavy.

Page 18

Echo sat down with a big sigh. "This is impossible! No matter how hard I try, the mountain pushes me back. My trying isn't working."

Page 19

She remembered Shelly's words: *Try, try, try*. Then Echo tilted her head. "And maybe try in a new way," she said softly.

Page 20

Echo studied the gravel. "If I can't go up," she said, "I'll try going sideways!"

Page 21

She shuffled left and right in a tiny zig-zag dance. Zig, zag. Zig, zag.

Page 22

It worked! Echo wasn't sliding anymore. She reached solid ground and squealed with delight. "I did it!"

Page 23

The summit was close now, but thick gray mist rolled in. The path vanished, and Echo could no longer see the peak.

Page 24

The sacred knots returned. Echo hugged her lantern tight. Its glow showed only the next few feet of ground.

Page 25

"I don't need to see the whole mountain," Echo whispered. "I just need to see the next step."

Page 26

One, two, three. Echo followed her circle of light, step by step, keeping her eyes right where she stood.

Page 27

Suddenly, her foot landed on a warm, flat rock. The mist swept away like a curtain opening.

Page 28

Echo gasped. She was standing on the very top of the Shimmering Peak! The stars glittered close by, like diamonds in the sky.

Page 29

Beside a smooth stone grew the flower. It was even more beautiful than the stories had promised.

Page 30

Echo gently touched a petal. The flower shimmered with color pink for pride, blue for bravery, and sparkling gold for joy, each one glowing brighter with every brave choice Echo remembered making.

Page 31

Echo smiled as the same colors glowed inside her heart. She wasn't just a small axolotl anymore. She was a Great Explorer.

Page 32

Echo tucked a petal safely into her cloak. She knew now that even the biggest mountains are made of little steps and with brave choices and clever thinking, she could always find a way.